

"A cricket game for VR on Steam"

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Could you share the new developments happening over in the backend of Wicked Witch?

DANIEL We have a dedicated team for the Wicked Witch 3D Engine, which is a cross platform engine across Playstation, Xbox, Android, Apple, Smart TVs and even wearables! Along with it, we are also focusing heavily on the graphics performance and cutting edge camera techniques. Rendering is another important area of focus that we are beefing up and all of this is in the pipeline.

What are the advantages of using a custom engine rather than adopting one of the major commercially available engines or even open source engines out there?

DANIEL Yes, we have our own custom game engine called the Wicked Witch 3D engine! We know this not a very creative name but that's what we call it. We have been working on the engine for about five years now. We did use other game engines in the past, but at the end of the day, we found that it was important to get maximum performance out of the device and for that we really wanted to write low level to the hardware and thus created our own engine from scratch. Everything, all the libraries, all the rendering, all the sound, all the input, gameplay, animation, everything from ground to up, the custom engine is built and used just so that we can get extra performance out of the machines that it runs on.

Along with performance, some of the other features of the Wicked Witch 3D

engine are that it doesn't have any bugs. If anything goes wrong, we can fix it at the end of the day right here where as with third party engines, you might end up in trouble looking for the solution whereas because we, ourselves have created everything in this engine from the low level right up the high level, we can modify and change and fix any bugs. That allows us towards the end of the project to get right down to the nuts and bolts to make sure we can do anything that we need to do.

Speaking about specific features, the rendering part is where we are focusing at the moment. Lighting is very, very important along with getting shadows at a high resolution. We need to make sure that things look great in sunrise, night time as well as at the time of sunset. Graphics is what we are really focusing on this moment.

Any plans to make the Wicked Witch 3D engine open source?

DANIEL Going open source has come up a number of times. The engine has been evolving with every game that we make but I don't think we will be going open source because of the amount of documentation and support that would be required. We don't have the capacity to support thousands of people that could be using our engine, right now. The engine is being used by our team as of now, but maybe one day it surely can go open source.

Any Virtual Reality games in the making? Does the engine support it?

DANIEL We love VR. We had the Oculus Rift DK1 development kit and since then the whole studio fell in love it. Since we also have the HTC Vive development kit, the Samsung Gear and the Oculus development kit, we are currently developing a cricket game for the Vive on Steam. We chose a cricket game for VR as you don't have to move around too much and can stand still in front of the wickets as the batsman or as a bowler and look around the stadium to find the open spots and plant your shots appropriately. It is an amazing experience and we hope to bring that to market within the next few months. There would just be a small game, a small branded game to start with and we hope to expand it from there.

We will also be experimenting with some of our other titles as well if it can support VR. We just have to make it run faster, have to make sure there is no latency for a rich VR experience.

What genres of games does Wicked Witch enjoy developing? RTS, RPG, Simulation, or something else altogether?

DANIEL We have developed a lot of sports games and are very good at it. We also enjoy developing real time strategy and role playing games, a lot of world of warcraft passionate guild leaders in the studio! *